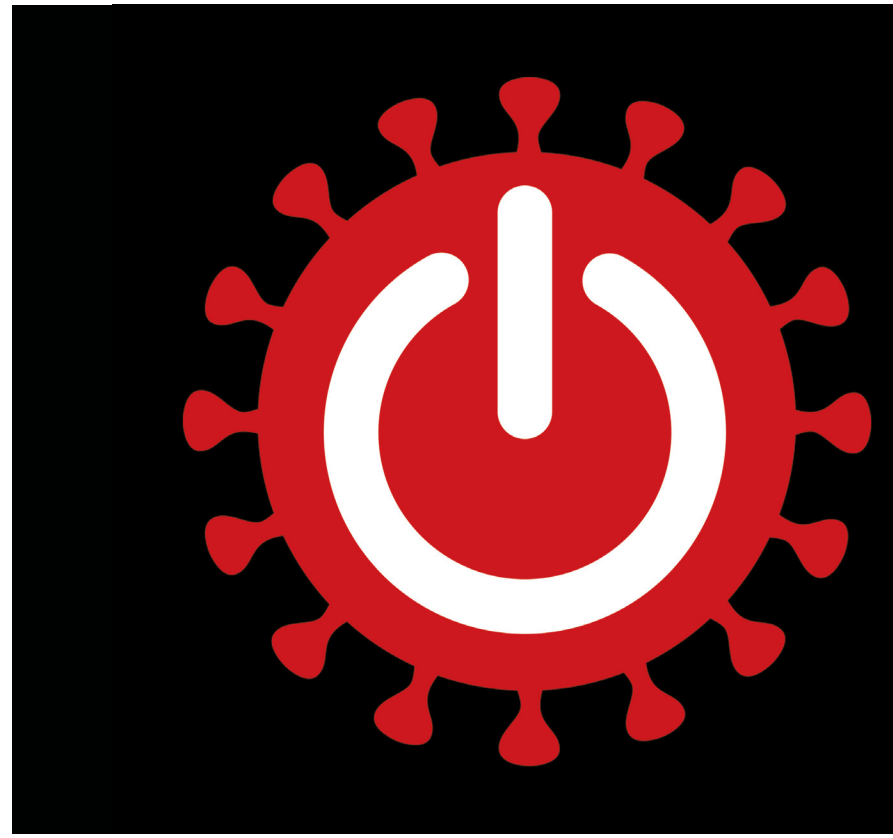


By
GAGANDEEP KANG

WILL 2022 BRING RELIEF FROM COVID?

OMICRON SHOWED US THAT NEW MUTANT COVID STRAINS ARE STILL EMERGING. SCIENCE AND PUBLIC HEALTH NEED TO BE AT THE FOREFRONT OF OUR CONTROL EFFORTS, SUPPORTED BY ENABLING POLICY IF WE ARE TO BEAT THE VIRUS



The year 2021 started in an exhilarating manner—with the promise of vaccines and lowering cases in India, against a background threat of what was called the UK variant at the time (now known as alpha), for which flights from the UK were temporarily halted. India's vaccine story was progressing, even though it was already clear that the rosy projections of timelines and number of doses made by the leading manufacturers were not being met. This reflected later in the year with the slow increase in vaccination and the struggles to obtain doses in the first half of 2021, even though after an initial sharing of doses as purchases and donations, India shut down vaccine exports to serve its own needs as cases increased through the latter half of February and then exploded in the next two months.

In hindsight, it all seems obvious. A new variant, slow vaccination and mass gatherings which included local and long distance travel created the perfect storm to overwhelm the less than robust healthcare systems, particularly in northern India. The desperation to use anything and everything flying in the face of any form of evidence-based medicine created India's second epidemic of the 'black fungus', unique to India and a reminder that over-treatment comes with consequences. People died, with numbers still disputed, but likely to be underestimated in many states. Families who were already reeling with economic losses and social disruptions, struggled to find hospital beds and help. By the beginning of June, we were in a better place, with declining cases and an irrational decision on vaccine supply reversed. But for the rest of the world, their delta story was just beginning.

The pattern for how the SARS-CoV2

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**